May We Reach the Shore

By Sarah Liu

“I can’t believe this!” Abram exclaimed, shivering as an icy wind blew his blond hair into his eyes. His breath bloomed in white clouds as he spoke. “We graduate tomorrow from being trainees, and we’re still stuck on the watchtower night shift!” He groaned loudly and turned his head to halfheartedly squint out at the vast expanse of ocean surrounding Carl’s Isle. As he did, spray from the saltwater stung his eyes.

“Lower your voice,” Marco muttered, glancing over his shoulder. “We swore that we would guard the island years ago.” If the higher-ups heard talk like that, it wouldn't just be treason; rather, it would be the end of everything Marco was trying to preserve.

Abram kicked a small pebble nearby, shooting it across the weathered wooden floor. “What are we even protecting this place from? It’s not like those other humans outside the island are intelligent or anything.” He rolled his eyes. Marco was the only person who needed a weekly reminder of this basic textbook fact. Did he not believe it? What reason did he have to not? It was such a silly thought that Abram couldn’t help but crack a small smile.

Marco sighed at Abram’s arrogance. At this rate, Abram would get both of them kicked out of the military and thrown into the underground prison. Abram didn’t seem to take this seriously, with his family residing in the Upper Class Homes. Memories of pushing his little sister’s wheelchair through the cramped streets of the Lower Class Fields shoved themselves free

from the corner of his mind Marco usually kept them locked in. He couldn't afford to be as carefree as his friend.

The two fell into a tense silence as they continued to watch the ocean through the wind. All Abram could see was a small glint of light that was quickly concealed by the surging. There really was no point in this. The ocean was silent save for the violent waves; nothing seemed to be out of the ordinary.

All of a sudden, Abram whipped his head back to look closer at the source of the light that had shone in the ocean. What could that possibly be? It was clear that it was too large to be a standard boat. Strangest of all, however, was that it moved smoothly without needing sails. As it neared, the roaring sound it emitted became deafening, forcing Abram to clap his hands over his ears. A burnt smell seemed to waft through the air from the object, at which Marco gagged.

"Abram!" Marco's sharp yell jolted Abram out of his awe-induced trance. "What is that? We must report it to Commander Vance at once! Follow me!"

The two climbed off the watchtower as fast as they could, their hands slipping on the saltwater-soaked iron. By the time they scrambled down the stone steps at the entrance to the courtyard, they were both out of breath. Marco hastily saluted and motioned for Abram to do the same. "Sir! There is an unidentified object moving through the water and toward the shore!"

The commander stood swiftly. He had a great, unobstructed view of the ocean from where he stood. At the sight of the colossal thing cutting through the water, his face paled and his breath caught in his throat. An uncomfortable moment passed as the commander fidgeted. Two section commanders sitting beside him looked at each other nervously. Marco tried to ignore it. Perhaps it was just nerves.

"Listen closely, you two," he barked, though it was clearly less commanding than his previous ones during training. "You must swim out and board the ship without being seen, then inspect it. Don't come back until you've thoroughly investigated it. Try not to drown on the way there; I wouldn't want all that water training to go to waste."

Abram froze, his blood running colder than the wind. Beside him, Marco stiffened as well. A chill ran through Marco's spine. Something was off about the commander's order, but there was no way. The commander had taken care of them ever since they'd enlisted.

Abram felt a tightening in his chest, and he massaged it roughly to try and cast it away. "You want us to *swim* in the freezing water?" he shrieked. "Are you serious? And towards that…that unknown *thing*? Are you *trying* to get us killed?" Privately, he wondered how the commander had confirmed that the object was a ship in a matter of seconds, though he pushed the thought aside in favor of more urgent matters.

At the outburst, the commander's eyebrows shot up. "Are you saying you won't follow my commands?"

“No, he wasn’t!” Marco interjected fearfully. “Abram, let’s go.” With that, he forcefully hauled the boy away. He knew that the commander’s commands were reckless and, quite frankly, irresponsible, but there was nothing two trainees could do about it. Once they had arrived at the shore, he stripped away his and Abram’s leather vests, leaving only their thin tunics that billowed in the wind. “Let’s go. Don’t you dare pull something like that again,” he warned before he dived into the freezing water. Abram followed closely. Despite his fear, he felt a sense of excitement that was quickly doused as the freezing water hit his skin. The two quickly swam towards the anchored ship as fast as they could, barely even coming up for breaths before diving back down, and soon made it to the ship, climbing aboard with difficulty. The ladder was quite a bit above the waves, forcing Abram to lift Marco in the air first before grabbing onto the hand extended to him after Marco had made it aboard.

Once they had made it onto the ship, they noticed most of the people seemed to be on the other side of the deck, rendering their side almost empty. Privately, Marco thanked the heavens as they wrung out what seemed like gallons of water from their clothes in a secluded corner. Now, he wouldn’t have to make up a pathetic cover story that nobody would believe as to why two teenagers were standing on the deck of the ship in soaking clothing while simultaneously shivering with chattering teeth. Not to mention how purple their faces were; Marco knew that they likely were suffering from hypothermia.

As they made their way down the deck and snuck past the sparse groups of people, they overheard a woman talking to her group of friends as they stood around at an elevated table with

a man behind serving colorful concoctions of liquid. Marco's stomach dropped to his toes as the women turned and looked them up and down, and he could tell that Abram had noticed too with the way his eyes dropped shamefully. Even the man gave them a strange look, though he returned to his drinks a moment later, apparently deciding that he had more important things to worry about.

"Hey, why are we still stopped here? This isn't on the map that the captain gave us."

"I dunno. I think the crew said something about the captain going off course or something. Probably got lost in this darkness."

"Where is this place anyway? And what's with those kids over there? Are they performers? Why're they wet?"

"I don't know about those kids. They must've fallen into the pool or something. Hey, excuse me?"

Marco flinched as the women turned to him and Abram. "Y-yeah?"

"You know that you should dry off after being in the pool, right? In this weather, you'll get hypothermia before you know it, and you won't be able to preform." The woman tilted her head in concern. "You brought towels, right?"

“Um, yeah, of course!” Marco lied. “Yeah, definitely.”

The woman nodded slowly before returning to her conversation with her friend. “What did you say about this place again? To me, it just looks like a primitive little island. Is it even on Google Maps?”

Abram couldn’t even process what a “Google Maps” was, his brain latching the words uttered prior to that phrase. His stomach seemed to drop into his bare feet, and the world around him seemed to sink into a stuffy silence. Primitive? Little island? The words seemed to hang in his chest. He stared at the woman’s shiny red dress; unnaturally smooth and brightly colored, then at his own rugged, soaking-wet military tunic. It felt coarser than ever against his skin.

A new problem arose in his mind. This couldn’t be true. The voice of his school teacher reading from the textbooks, repeating the “fact” that non-islanders were unintelligent echoed in his head. *Across the ocean, though there may be humankind, they are unintelligent and possess no knowledge. Simply put, they live like animals, and pose virtually no threat to the people of this island.* Had this information been a lie? Propaganda? The more Abram thought, the less he could deny the truth of this new revelation no matter how hard he tried. It didn’t help that he was staring right into the glowing object clutched in the woman’s hand.

Just then, a voice boomed throughout the ship, making the two cringe at the sheer volume. “Passengers and crew, we will now be getting back on course and leaving the shore of this island.”

“Abram, we need to leave, or we’ll be carried away from the island!” Marco tried to tug him to the edge, but Abram resisted. It felt as though he couldn’t move his limbs, as if they were numb with shock.

“Marco, please stay!” He blurted out after a moment. “Don’t you want to see what the world outside of the island is like?”

“No! I don’t understand what is happening, or what is wrong with any of these people, but I’m not sticking around to find out! Come *on! Hurry!*”

Abram let go of Marco’s hand. “Then go! I’m staying here.”

Marco gawked at him owlishly. “Are you crazy? Do you even know how you’ll survive out there?” He reached to grab Abram’s hand again, but he evaded his grasp, stepping back until his back hit the steel wall with a loud *thud*. “Stop it! Stop running away, Abram!” His voice reached a shrill tone, cracking slightly. His eyes burned. Abram couldn’t get away; he wouldn’t let him. “Think about your parents! Michael! He’s your little brother, you couldn’t possibly leave him! Please, you need to *think it through!*”

Suddenly, the boat began to stir once more, starting to turn around. Both boys gasped. It was now or never.

The image of his little sister flashed through Marco's mind—Anne, with her dirtied bows barely holding her braids together. He couldn't leave her. With their parents gone, he was already barely able to keep her safe. The thought of abandoning her made his stomach churn; there was no way she would survive without him.

There was no other choice. Abram wasn't more important than his dear Anne.

"I guess you're staying, then…" Marco's words trailed off as he turned his back on Abram and approached the edge of the deck. Clumsily climbing over the railing, he jumped off quickly. The freezing water hit him, water flowing into his nose and mouth. Choking and coughing, he began to frantically swim back towards the island.

Abram slid to the deck floor, grabbing his hair. Was Marco right? What about Michael? His mother? His father? He didn't know if he regretted his impulsive decision. What would become of his family? Would they be shamed for having a son who deserted their homeland? What would Abram do without them?

A wave of doubt threatened to pull him under. Had he made the wrong choice? No, he told himself, though even his inner voice faltered. He had made the right choice. Closing his eyes against the rising panic, he held tightly to the only truth driving him.

He simply needed to know.